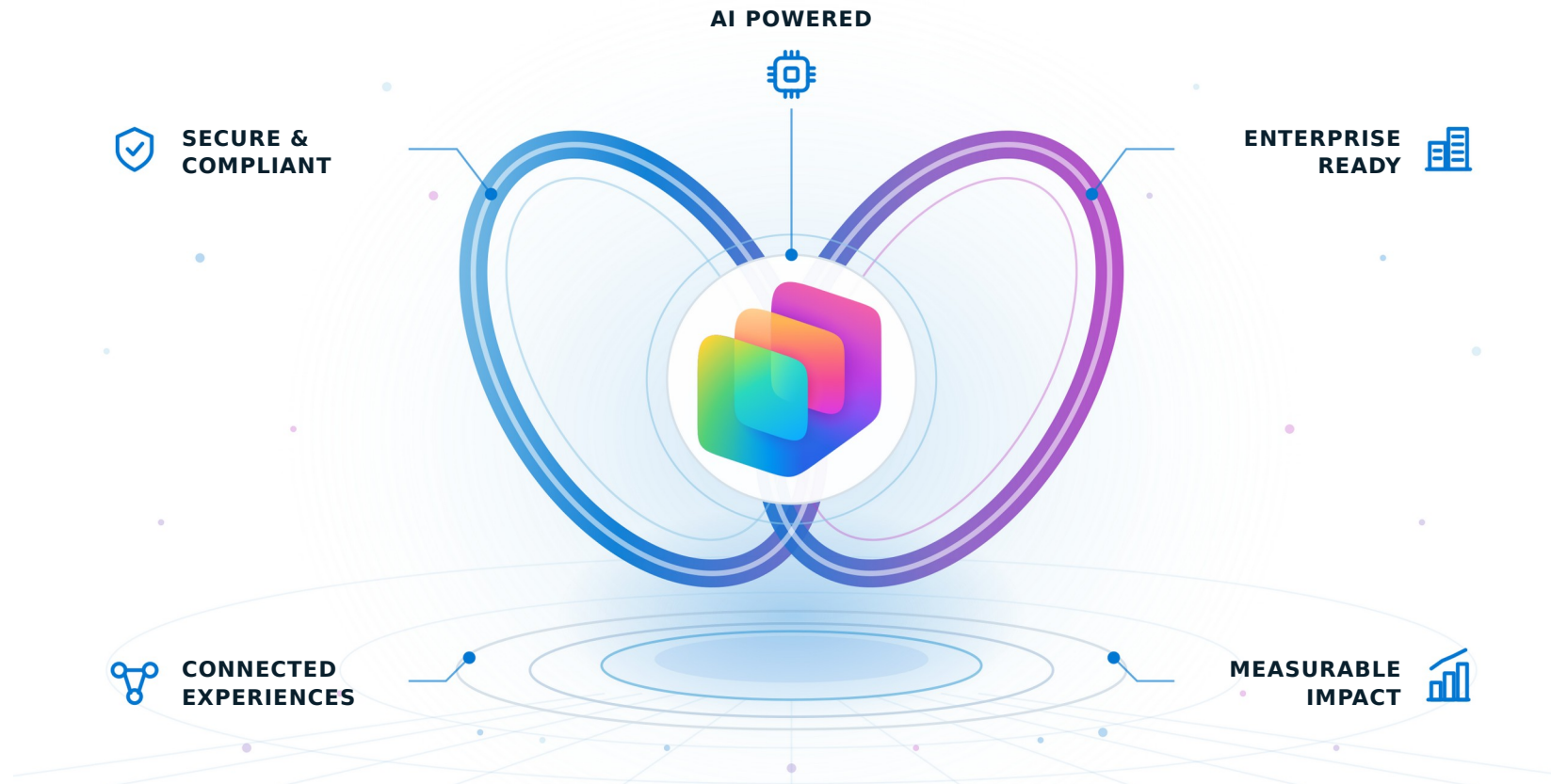


Harnesses, Licensing & Copilot Credits

What Microsoft 365 Copilot covers — and what it never has

Vinod Dhanwe | Snr Solutions Architect

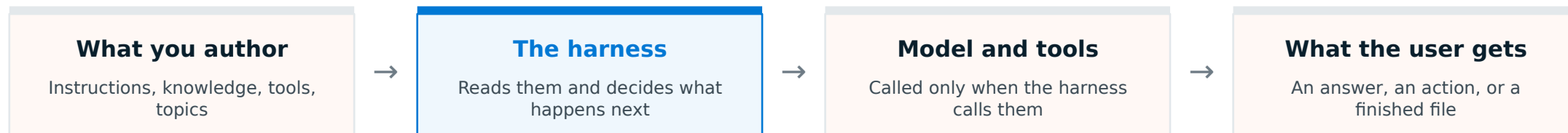
Verified against Microsoft Learn documentation, August 2026



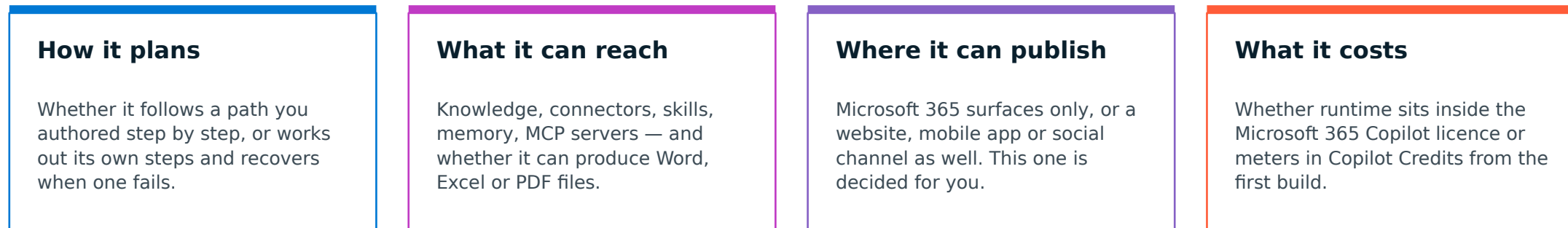
What a harness is, and what it does for you

A harness is the runtime your agent runs on.

You author the instructions, the knowledge and the tools. The harness is what reads them while the agent is running — deciding when to call the model, what context to send it, which tool to reach for next, and how to turn the result into an answer. Give two agents identical instructions on different harnesses and they will not behave the same way.



THE HARNESS DECIDES FOUR THINGS — AND YOU LIVE WITH ALL FOUR



Choose the harness first. Capability, reach and cost all follow from it — and it cannot be changed once the agent exists.

Three harnesses, one studio

Copilot chat harness

Extends Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat

Grounds Copilot Chat in your SharePoint, Teams and Outlook content.

Publishes to internal teams only.

Included in M365 Copilot USL (fair use)

Standard harness

Rule-based agents and agent flows

Topics, triggers, Power Fx, Adaptive Cards. Predictable by design.

Internal or external.

Free to build · rate card at runtime, fair use for USL

GitHub Copilot harness

Reasoning-heavy, multi-step work

Plans its own steps, recovers from failure, writes Office files, skills + memory + MCP.

Internal or external.

Usage-based credits — from the first build action



Copilot Studio

One platform carries all three — and the harness cannot be changed after the agent is created

What each harness is actually for

Copilot chat harness

Reach for it when employees need grounded answers inside Microsoft 365, and nobody outside the organisation will ever use it.

TYPICAL USE CASES

- Compliance and policy Q&A over SharePoint
- Regulatory change briefings for advisors
- Onboarding and HR policy answers in Teams
- Fund and product fact-sheet lookup
- Internal "where do I find..." routing

Not for: anything a client touches, and anything that has to run on a schedule.

Standard harness

Reach for it when you already know the path through the conversation and you need it to run the same way every time.

TYPICAL USE CASES

- Client onboarding intake with validation
- Service desk triage and ticket creation
- KYC document checklist walkthrough
- Website FAQ and appointment booking
- Structured data capture into Dataverse

The auditable option — every path is authored, so you can show a regulator exactly what it does.

GitHub Copilot harness

Reach for it when you cannot map the path in advance and the work spans documents, systems and judgement.

TYPICAL USE CASES

- Invoice matching and exception routing
- Credit memo drafting from several sources
- AML alert triage with a written narrative
- Portfolio review packs in Word and Excel
- Multi-system loan file assembly

The expensive option, and sometimes the only one. Pilot a real workload before you commit.

If two harnesses could both do the job, take the cheaper one — that is almost always Standard.

Fair use: four conditions, all must hold

Microsoft 365 Copilot covers Standard and Copilot chat harness runtime only when every one of these is true. Fail any single condition and the published rate card applies.

1

Licensed user

The person using the agent holds a Microsoft 365 Copilot USL.

2

Microsoft surface

The interaction happens in Copilot, Teams or SharePoint — not a website, WhatsApp or app.

3

Authenticated identity

The agent runs under that user's signed-in identity — not anonymously, not unattended.

4

Within fair use

Undefined publicly. Microsoft reserves the right to revise the limits as usage patterns emerge.

Condition 3 is the one that surprises people — it is what puts autonomous runs outside the licence.

Standard harness + autonomous actions = credits

A Standard harness agent is only free while a licensed person is driving it.

Add a schedule, an event trigger or a Power Automate call and the run becomes unattended. There is no authenticated Microsoft 365 Copilot identity behind it, so condition 3 fails and every action meters at the published rate — on the same agent, on the same harness, in the same tenant.

WHAT MICROSOFT DOCUMENTS

Agent flows

The "no charge" inclusion applies only to the When an agent calls the flow trigger. Flows on any other trigger consume credits at the standard rate.

Computer-Using Agents

CUA usage is explicitly excluded from the Microsoft 365 Copilot USL — billed at the agent-action rate regardless of licence.

Proactive greetings

An agent that opens a conversation on its own is billed as a classic answer, even if nobody replies.

Enforcement scope

The overage policy covers custom agent usage "conversational and autonomously triggered" — Microsoft meters both.

MICROSOFT'S OWN WORKED EXAMPLE

Order processing agent

An internal-facing agent, autonomously triggered whenever a new order arrives. It confirms availability, checks shipping, approves the order and emails the customer — four agent actions in generative orchestration.

4 actions × 5 credits = 20 credits per run

Note what is missing: the phrase "internal-facing" earns no discount here. Microsoft costs this agent in credits because it is autonomously triggered — the licence never enters the calculation.

The published rate card

Every figure below is Microsoft's, from Billing rates and management. The right-hand column is the whole argument: "no charge" is conditional, and the conditions are the four on the previous slide.

Agent feature	Billing rate	Licensed M365 Copilot user
Classic answer	1 credit	No charge
Generative answer	2 credits	No charge
Agent action (triggers, deep reasoning, topic transitions)	5 credits	No charge
Tenant graph grounding	10 credits	No charge
Agent flow actions (per 100 actions)	13 credits	Only on agent-calls-flow trigger
Text & generative AI tools — standard	15 credits	No charge
Text & generative AI tools — premium (reasoning)	100 credits	No charge
Computer-Using Agents (CUA)	5 credits	Excluded from the USL

Charges stack. One grounded reasoning answer is a generative answer plus tenant graph grounding plus the premium token rate — 112 credits, not 2.

What changes when nobody is driving

Attended · user-invoked

- An advisor opens the agent in Teams
- Runs under their authenticated identity
- They hold a Microsoft 365 Copilot USL
- Microsoft surface, inside fair use

No charge

Four conditions hold. The runtime is included in the licence.

Unattended · autonomously triggered

- A schedule or event fires the agent
- No signed-in user session exists
- The USL has no identity to attach to
- Every action meters at the rate card

Billed in credits

Condition 3 fails. Nothing else about the agent changed.

Design consequence: the moment you add a schedule or trigger to an internal Standard-harness agent, it leaves the licence. Budget it like a metered workload, not a free one.

Covered, and not covered

Covered — included in the M365 Copilot USL

- Grounding Copilot Chat in SharePoint policy libraries
- Regulatory and compliance knowledge for licensed staff
- Employee onboarding answers inside Teams and Copilot
- Custom instructions and suggested prompts
- Building, configuring and testing the agent

Not covered — credits, or not possible at all

- External customers — the harness cannot publish externally
- Users without a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence
- Anonymous or unauthenticated access
- Usage beyond fair-use limits
- Autonomous triggers, schedules and unattended runs

The constraint that decides it before anything else

The Copilot chat harness publishes to internal teams only. If the agent will ever face a customer, a partner portal or a public website, this harness is out — however well it fits on every other axis. That decision comes first, because the harness cannot be changed after the agent is created.

Coverage by harness and condition

Scenario	Copilot chat	Standard	GitHub Copilot
Licensed user · Teams / SharePoint / Copilot	Free	Free	Credits
Licensed user · external channel	Not possible	Credits	Credits
Unlicensed or anonymous user	Credits	Credits	Credits
Autonomous trigger or schedule	Credits	Credits	Credits
Computer-Using Agent (CUA)	n/a	Credits	Credits
Build, author and configure	Free	Free	Credits
Preview, test and evaluate	Free	Free	Credits
Fair-use inclusion applies?	Yes, limited	Yes, limited	No

"Free" means included in the Microsoft 365 Copilot USL under fair use. Every free cell depends on all four conditions holding.

Four scenarios, four answers

1. Compliance FAQ for internal advisors

Standard harness · Teams · 200 licensed advisors · user-invoked

All four conditions hold. This is the shape of agent the licence was written for.

No charge

2. The same agent, opened to external advisors

Standard harness · web channel · 50 unlicensed contractors

External channel and unlicensed users. Compare the credit run-rate against simply licensing the contractors.

Rate card

3. Overnight AML screening run

Standard harness · scheduled trigger · no user session

The autonomous case. Same harness as scenario 1, yet it meters on every action.

Rate card

4. Invoice matching and exception routing

GitHub Copilot harness · reads documents, plans, recovers

The only harness that can do this work. Budget from the first build session, not from go-live.

Usage-based

Governance and cost control

Do this

- Inventory every agent and record its harness
- Flag which agents carry a schedule or event trigger — those are your metered ones
- Set per-agent monthly limits with the hard stop in the Power Platform admin centre
- Model with the Copilot Studio usage estimator before you commit
- Get written fair-use scope for your top three scenarios at renewal

Avoid this

- Assuming "internal agent" means "free agent" — the trigger decides, not the audience
- Planning a customer-facing agent on the Copilot chat harness
- Treating alerts as caps — only deny and the per-agent hard stop actually stop spend
- Letting new environments draw on the tenant pool unchecked
- Quoting a per-run price for the GitHub Copilot harness before you have piloted it

Watch the calendar

Developer and trial environments move to usage-based billing on 1 September 2026. Overage enforcement disables custom agents at 125% of prepaid capacity — for conversational and autonomously triggered usage alike. Agent-flow enforcement blocks new runs while leaving the parent agent answering.

Five things that decide the bill

1 **The harness is a one-way door**

Chosen at creation and unchangeable. Variables, Power Fx and topic Adaptive Cards are standard-harness only.

2 **Standard and Copilot chat are conditionally free**

Building and testing cost nothing. Runtime is included only while all four fair-use conditions hold.

3 **Autonomous runs are never included**

Schedules, event triggers and unattended flows meter on every harness — including the two the licence otherwise covers.

4 **GitHub Copilot harness meters from the first build action**

No licence covers it, and no fair-use carve-out exists. Reach for it when the work genuinely needs judgement.

5 **Fair use is undefined and revisable**

Pilot a real workload, read the consumption report, then model. Do not quote a per-run price from a rate card alone.

VERIFY IT YOURSELF

Sources

Everything in this deck traces to Microsoft documentation. Confirm before you budget — this area is moving, and the GitHub Copilot harness reached general availability only on 3 August 2026.

Billing rates and management

learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/requirements-messages-management

The rate card, the four-action worked example, footnotes 1 and 4, and the enforcement policy covering autonomously triggered usage.

Choose a harness

learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/harnesses-overview

The definition of a harness and the capability comparison across all three.

Standard harness licensing

learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/billing-licensing

Licence paths, credit mechanics and capacity enforcement.

FAQ for billing and licensing

learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/faq-billing-licensing

Proactive greetings, Teams-channel nuances and publishing prerequisites.

Usage-based billing overview

learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/agents-experience/billing-credit-overview

Why the GitHub Copilot harness bills from the first build action.

Copilot Studio Licensing Guide, August 2026

go.microsoft.com/fwlink/?linkid=2320995

The authoritative billing matrix across all three harnesses.

Questions

Choose the harness before you build — it cannot be changed afterwards.

And remember what the licence actually covers: a licensed person, on a Microsoft surface, driving the agent themselves.

The moment something else starts the run, you are paying in credits.